



Of stepwell and ghosts

Inside BGMI 4.0 update with Krafton India's **Karan Gaikwad**

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When Krafton dropped the teaser for its latest point of interest in Erangel, the Stepwell, millions of mobile gamers in India got pretty excited. After all, it is always nice to have something inspired from our own architecture in a game played by over 200 million users. The stepwell, or a baori is a traditional Indian structure featuring a descending series of steps that lead down to the water. While it was earlier used to store groundwater, it also makes a great place for a gunfight in a battle royale game like BGMI.

According to Karan Gaikwad, Lead of Product at Krafton India, the objective with The Stepwell was to give players "a truly Indian experience." In an exclusive conversation with Digit, Gaikwad talked about the latest BGMI 4.0 update, India's mobile gaming landscape, and a few other things that gamers should care about.

The debate around Stepwell

When asked what was the largest debate in the room before and while designing the Stepwell for BGMI players, Gaikwad said, "The debate was largely around what and which loca-

tion do we select. A lot of time went into arriving at the idea of a stepwell."

He added, "The other thing in our mind was to ensure that whatever we select is also fun to play in - are there enough places to cover from? Enough places to hide rewards in? Does it look grand? Does it look different but familiar enough so that people can recognise it as something which is truly Indian."

The larger debate, he added, was around the technical implementations once the idea of a stepwell was zeroed in. Gaikwad further explains, "There is always back and forth between the creative and technical. Creative wants everything, texture and all. But then technical guys are

like 'not everyone owns an iPhone and we need to make the game work on all devices'. So, the debate was around how do we bring this idea to life in a game that is played by millions of Indians. And the discussions were more on a technical level."

Element of randomness and a secret spot

Stepwell also introduces layered vertical gameplay, which can be tough to balance in battle royale titles. "We tackle this through randomness," Karan explained.

"It's the core of this game... there is a level of randomness which ensures that the game is fun every time you play it. There could be some open

